

Shramdan by Hon'ble CM Bhupendra Patel during SHS

norms. Yet, with focused policies, grassroots participation, and a commitment to innovation, Gujarat began a journey that would become a model for the nation.

THE JOURNEY FROM VISION TO REALITY

Over the past decade, Gujarat's journey under the Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin (SBM-G) has been remarkable. The state has transitioned from achieving Open Defecation-Free (ODF) status to embracing long-term sustainability through the ODF Plus initiatives. By December 2024, Gujarat constructed an impressive 43.5 lakh Individual Household Latrines (IHHLs) and over 7,000 Community Sanitary Complexes (CSCs). These milestones provided inclusive sanitation access to millions.

Yet, Gujarat's vision extended beyond building infrastructure. The state focused on behavioral change, solid and liquid waste management (SLWM), and maintaining visual cleanliness in villages. In 33 districts, 248 blocks now boast 9,343 segregation sheds and a fleet of 18,000 waste collection vehicles. Greywater management systems and community soak pits have revolutionized wastewater treatment.

To ensure sustainability, Gujarat has worked on strengthening its Rural Sanitation Policy. This policy focuses on enhancing infrastructure operations and maintaining the dignity of sanitation workers. Nature-based solutions, such as using constructed wetlands for wastewater treatment, are being promoted. Urban-rural convergence, where urban waste management practices are adapted for rural contexts, has also been a priority. These comprehensive measures demonstrate Gujarat's commitment to not just achieving, but sustaining, rural sanitation goals.

GOBARDHAN SCHEME: INNOVATIVE INITIATIVES AND THE POWER OF BIOGAS

One of the most transformative initiatives under SBM-G in Gujarat is the Gobardhan Scheme. This program converts cow dung and organic waste into clean energy, promoting both sanitation and sustainability. To date, 7,400 biogas plants have been installed across the state, with plans for an additional 10,000 plants in 50 clusters by 2024-25, backed by ₹25.5 crore in state funding.

These biogas plants have had a far-reaching impact. In addition to reducing dependence on firewood and LPG, they are empowering rural communities. In Anand, for instance, a single biogas plant powers 200 rural households, providing a cleaner, healthier cooking alternative. The manure produced from these plants supports sustainable agriculture, completing a cycle of eco-friendly development.

The Gobardhan initiative has also fostered a culture of innovation in waste management. Villages are now seeing organic waste not as a problem, but as a resource. The installation of these biogas plants has also improved the lives of women, who no longer have to spend hours collecting firewood. This has freed up their time for education, employment, and personal growth.

COLLECTIVE EFFORTS: THE POWER OF COLLABORATION

Gujarat's success story is a testament to the power of collaboration. The state's achievements are driven by the 4Ps: People's Participation, Political Will, Strategic Partnerships, and Public Finance. This multi-faceted approach has brought together various stakeholders, each contributing to the mission's success.

Gram Panchayats have played a critical role in implementing SBM-G at the grassroots level. The involvement of private entities like ITC, Nayara Energy, Ambuja Cement, and Tata Trusts has brought in additional expertise and resources. Academic institutions have provided research and technological support, helping to develop innovative solutions for rural sanitation challenges.

BUILDING BLOCKS OF A CLEAN FUTURE

- 43.5 lakh Individual Household Latrines (IHHLs) and 7,000 Community Sanitary Complexes (CSCs) were constructed.
- 9,343 segregation sheds support waste management across 248 blocks.
- 18,000 waste collection vehicles operate across 33 districts.
- Greywater management systems and soak pits address wastewater concerns.

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The Lighthouse Initiative (LHI) has further strengthened these collaborative efforts. LHI has created model blocks that showcase best practices in sanitation and waste management. These model blocks serve as learning centers for other regions, accelerating progress toward Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) Target 6.2, which aims to achieve access to adequate and equitable sanitation for all.

The Commissionerate of Rural Development (CRD) has established a call center to track data

As per UNICEF study health benefits include a reduction of 6,340.3 tones of CO_2 annually, curbing greenhouse emissions and improving indoor air quality. Women benefit from reduced time spent gathering firewood, enabling them to engage in education and income-generating activities. Financially, households save an average of INR 42,804 annually, primarily from reduced LPG and fertilizer costs. Additionally, selling organic manure adds INR2,000-3,000 per month for farmers. This circular economy model enhances rural sustainability while promoting clean energy and empowering communities.





Involvement of Sanitation workers during SHS